

THEMES

A theme is a major aspect of your character such as their unique skill set, technology, Mythical power, background, life mission, or personality. This aspect is represented by a collection of tags and other game features.

A player character has four themes. The aspects of your character represented by a theme will have the most impact on the story, for better or worse. Your character may have other aspects, which are not represented by a theme; for example they might have close friends or a piece of backstory not represented by a theme. These are still a part of your character, but they don't have direct game effects and therefore will probably not receive as much attention in the series as your themed aspects.



Your themes can change. Your character can and will undergo transformations that have them replace existing themes with new ones, making them a dynamic and evolving being with changing abilities and power sets.

THEME TYPES

A theme's type defines its focal point. There are 14 theme types presented in the core version of *:Otherscape*, divided into three categories. Each category represents one of the three major forces in the *:Otherscape* universe: Self, Mythos, and Noise.

- The **SELF** theme types represent your personal identity and all that defines you as a unique being. They include **Affiliation, Assets, Expertise, Horizon, Personality, and Troubled Past.**
- The **MYTHOS** theme types represent a major Source your character is using, the powers it grants you, and your relationship to it. They include **Artifact, Companion, Esoterica, and Exposure.**
- The **NOISE** theme types represent your superhuman technological abilities. They include **Augmentation, Cutting Edge, Cyberspace, and Drones.**

The balance of Self, Mythos, and Noise determines your character's cosmological nature as a being, your **Essence** (page 134) and your access to a specific Essence Special.

MOTIVATIONS & THE DECAY TRACK

Each theme has a motivation that defines how it drives your character to act in the world. The type of motivation is based on the theme's category:

- Self themes have an **Identity** that you have to uphold in order to maintain your connection with that part of yourself.
- Mythos themes have a **Ritual** that you have to perform to maintain your connection with that Source.
- Noise themes have an **Itch**, an impulse you have to satisfy in order to maintain your integration with that technology.

Acting against your Identity, neglecting your Ritual, or resisting your Itch can eventually lead you to replace your theme. Every time you turn your back on your motivation, you mark one **Decay** box on that theme's Decay track. Once you mark all three Decay boxes on a theme, you replace it with a different theme (see **Replacing Themes**, page 138). This represents your character ignoring or inhibiting a part of themselves for so long that it moved to the backburner, transformed, withered, or was lost. Another aspect then takes center stage, represented by a new theme.